

Mutiny Tests
China’s Bond
With Russia

Xi May Reassess Risks
of Siding With Putin

By DAVID PIERSON
and OLIVIA WANG

Just three months ago, China's top leader, Xi Jinping, was in Moscow clinking glasses with Vladimir V. Putin and expressing his confidence in the “firm support” the Russian president enjoyed among his people. That confidence is now in question, after the Wagner private military group waged an insurrection in Russia that has shaken Mr. Putin's image of invulnerability. Close watchers of China say that the mutiny, short-lived as it was, could lead Mr. Xi to hedge a close relationship with Russia that had already exposed Beijing to global criticism and threatened some of its interests abroad.

China views Russia as a necessary partner in challenging the global order dominated by the United States. But Mr. Putin's appetite for risk — seen in his invasion of Ukraine and his reliance on private armies — has forced Beijing to defend its bond with Russia in the face of Western pressure.

Mr. Xi's long-term bet will work only if Mr. Putin remains in control to help uphold the shared interests of both countries. But the revolt has raised questions about Mr. Putin's authority: Wagner soldiers faced little to no resistance from regular Russian forces as they advanced on Moscow. And Mr. Putin's decision to grant sanctuary in Belarus to Yevgeny V. Prigozhin, the leader of the uprising, smacked of a compromise rather than the act of a strongman with consolidated power.

“It makes China realize that the Putin government's internal politics are actually quite fragile,” said Xiao Bin, a researcher for the Institute of Russian, East European and Central Asian Studies at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences. “The fragility existed before, but it has increased ever since the start of the Russia-Ukraine war.”

China has publicly reaffirmed its support for the Kremlin following the insurrection, and analysts say the relationship is

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Moving body bags on the Greek Coast Guard ship 920 on June 14. More than 600 on the migrant ship Adriana died.

How Greece Failed a Migrant Ship
Performing a Law Enforcement Operation, Not a Rescue

By MATINA STEVIS-GRIDNEFF
and KARAM SHOUMALI

From air and by sea, using radar, telephone and radio, officials watched and listened for 13 hours as the migrant ship Adriana lost power, then drifted aimlessly off the coast of Greece in a slowly unfolding humanitarian disaster.

As terrified passengers telephoned for help, humanitarian workers assured them that a rescue team was coming. European border officials, watching aerial footage, prepared to witness what was certain to be a heroic operation.

Yet the Adriana capsized and sank in the presence of a single Greek Coast Guard ship last month, killing more than 600 migrants in a maritime tragedy that was shocking even for the world's deadliest migrant route.

Satellite imagery, sealed court documents, more than 20 interviews with survivors and officials, and a flurry of radio signals transmitted in the final hours suggest that the scale of death was preventable.



A Greek Coast Guard handout photo showing migrants on the Adriana.

Dozens of officials and coast guard crews monitored the ship, yet the Greek government treated the situation like a law enforcement operation, not a rescue. Rather than send a navy hospital ship or rescue specialists, the authorities sent a team that included four masked, armed men from a coast guard special operations unit.

The Greek authorities have repeatedly said that the Adriana was sailing to Italy, and that the migrants did not want to be rescued. But satellite imagery and tracking data obtained by The New York Times show definitively that the Adriana was drifting in a loop for its last six and a half hours. And in sworn testimony, survivors described passengers on the ship's upper decks calling for help and even trying to jump aboard a commercial tanker that had stopped to provide drinking water.

On board the Adriana, the roughly 750 passengers descended into violence and desperation. Every movement threatened to capsize the ship. Survivors described beatings and panic as they waited for a rescue that would never come.

The sinking of the Adriana is an extreme example of a longtime standoff in the Mediterranean. Ruthless smugglers in North Africa cram people onto shoddy vessels, and passengers hope that, if things go wrong, they will be taken to safety. But European coast guards often postpone rescues out of fear that helping

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IN COURT RULINGS,
THE CHIEF JUSTICE
EXHIBITS HIS SWAY

FORGING OF ALLIANCES

To Get Landmark Wins,
Roberts Leaned In
to Both Sides

By ADAM LIPTAK

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court ended its term last week in familiar fashion, issuing blockbuster conservative decisions on affirmative action, gay rights and student loans that divided along partisan lines, with the court's three Democratic appointees in dissent.

While not quite as stunning as last June's decisions eliminating the right to abortion and expanding gun rights, the new rulings were of a piece with them and were a further indication that the court remains receptive to the conservative legal movement's agenda, including cutting back on a progressive conception of civil rights and frustrating President Biden's initiatives.

But the entire story of the most recent term is considerably more complicated than that of the previous one, which had seemed to establish an unyielding conservative juggernaut characterized by impatience and ambition — and built to last.

A year later, the court remains deeply conservative but is more in tune with the fitfully incremental approach of Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr., who is attentive to his court's legitimacy, than with the take-no-prisoners approach of Justice Clarence Thomas. The chief justice's strategy — and votes — produced a fair number of liberal victories.

“Chief Justice Roberts seems to be getting at least some of the conservative majority back into harness on incremental moves,” said Pamela S. Karlan, a law professor at Stanford.

Indeed, the term that just ended was something of a triumph for the chief justice, who just a year ago seemed to be losing power, having failed to persuade a single colleague to join his compromise position in the case that died away with the constitutional right to abortion.

When the latest term started in October, Justice Thomas ap-

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A Sport Played With Paddles
Can Generate Quite a Racket

By ANDREW KEH

ARLINGTON, Va. — It sounded like popcorn warming in a microwave: sporadic bursts that quickened, gradually, to an arrhythmic clatter.

“There it is,” Mary McKee said, starting out the front door of her home in Arlington, Va., on a recent afternoon.

McKee, 43, a conference planner, moved to the neighborhood in 2005 and for the next decade and a half enjoyed a mostly tranquil existence. Then came the pickleball players.

She gestured across the street to the Walter Reed Community Center, less than 100 feet from her yard, where a group of players, the first of the day, had started rallying on a repurposed tennis court. More arrived in short order, spreading out until there were six games going at once. Together they produced an hourslong tick-

tock cacophony that has become the unwanted soundtrack of the lives of McKee and her neighbors.

“I thought maybe I could live with it, maybe it would fade into the background,” she said of the clamor, which began around the height of the coronavirus pandemic and now reverberates through her home, even when her windows are closed. “But it never did.”

Sports can produce all kinds of unpleasant noises: referees' whistles, rancorous boos, vuvuzelas. But the most grating and disruptive sound in the entire athletic ecosystem right now may be the staccato pop-pop-pop emanating from America's rapidly multiplying pickleball courts.

The sound has brought on a nationwide scourge of frayed nerves and unneighborly clashes — and those, in turn, have elicited peti-



Many neighbors of pickleball courts, like ones in Arlington, Va., above, say the incessant thwack from the games is torturous.

tions and calls to the police and last-ditch lawsuits aimed at the local parks, private clubs and homeowners associations that rushed to open courts during the sport's recent boom.

The hubbub has given new

Hunter Biden and the Politics
Of Paternity in the Media’s Glare

By KATIE ROGERS

BATESVILLE, Ark. — There is a 4-year-old girl in rural Arkansas who is learning to ride a camouflage-patterned four-wheeler alongside her cousins. Some days, she wears a bow in her hair, and on other days, she threads her long blond ponytail through the back of a baseball cap. When she is old enough, she will learn to hunt, just like her mother did when she was young.

The girl is aware that her father is Hunter Biden and that her paternal grandfather is the president of the United States. She speaks about both of them often, but she has not met them. Her maternal grandfather, Rob Roberts, described her as whip-smart and funny.

“I may not be the POTUS,” Mr. Roberts said in a text message, using an acronym for the president, but he said he would do anything for his granddaughter. He said she “needs for nothing and never will.”

The story surrounding the president's grandchild in Arkansas, who is not named in court papers, is a tale of two families, one of them powerful, one of them not. But at its core, the story is about money, corrosive politics and what it means to have the Biden birthright.

Her parents ended a yearslong court battle over child support on Thursday, agreeing that Mr. Biden, who has embarked on a second career as a painter whose pieces have been offered for as much as \$500,000 each, would turn over a number of his paintings to his daughter in addition to providing a monthly support payment. The little girl will select the paintings from Mr. Biden, accord-

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An Island They Call Home	There Goes Gravity	Singing for Two	Going Rogue Works for Him	Evgeny Morozov
Florida flew 49 migrants to Martha's Vineyard from Texas last year. Since then, a few have found work, friends and a new life on the island. PAGE 13	A once sleepy amusement park in Georgia has put itself on the map with a destination roller coaster that mimics the thrills of extreme sports. PAGE 8	A look at what women in opera gained, and lost, pursuing a career into pregnancy. “The industry still views you as their property,” one mother said. PAGE 6	Greg Gutfeld has ridden a fast wave from a 3 a.m. slot to a prime-time forum of merry trolling on Fox News that's beating “The Tonight Show.” PAGE 1	PAGE 6

